# Anti-Tanking Lottery Reform Analysis
# Impact on the Milwaukee Bucks

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## 1. Executive Summary

This analysis evaluates three proposed NBA draft lottery reforms through a Milwaukee Bucks-specific framework focused on draft upside, downside protection, value distribution, and competitive alignment. As a consistent contender with limited control over future first-round picks, Milwaukee operates under a constraint where traditional rebuild strategies provide minimal benefit.

Among the proposals, the 18-team flattened lottery (Proposal 1) best aligns with Milwaukee's priorities by increasing access to mid-tier upside while still valuing competition. Proposal 2 expands lottery access but dilutes meaningful outcomes, while Proposal 3 maintains a bottom-heavy structure that limits access to high-value draft positions.

Overall, draft systems that improve incremental upside without requiring bottom-tier positioning are most beneficial for Milwaukee. Proposal 1 therefore represents the optimal structure, preserving competitiveness while maintaining long-term flexibility.

## 2. Milwaukee Bucks Context

The Milwaukee Bucks have operated as a consistent Eastern Conference contender in recent seasons, limiting their access to high-value draft positions. As a result, changes to the NBA's draft lottery system have a unique impact on their ability to maintain competitiveness while preserving long-term flexibility.

As shown in *Figure 1*, the Bucks have consistently finished near the top of the standings in multiple recent seasons, resulting in late first-round, or even no first-round draft selections if that pick was already traded.

*Figure 1*

**Milwaukee Bucks Season Outcomes**

| Season | Record | East Finish | NBA Finish | Draft Picks |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **2024-25** | 48-34 | 5th | 13th | 1st - NA<br>2nd - 47th |
| **2023-24** | 49-33 | 3rd | 8th | 1st - 23rd<br>2nd - 33rd |
| **2022-23** | 58-24 | 1st | 1st | 1st - NA<br>2nd - 58th |
| **2021-22** | 51-31 | 3rd | 7th | 1st - 24th<br>2nd - 59th |
| **2020-21** | 46-26 | 3rd | 7th | 1st - NA<br>2nd - 31st |

Team Context

- Consistent top-tier Eastern Conference rank
- Draft position typically in late 1st round or later
- Limited access to lottery or top-tier draft talent
- Limited control of future 1st round picks

*Figure 2*

| Concept | Bucks Preference |
|---|---|
| **Tanking Reward** | ✗ Bad |
| **Mid-Tier Reward** | ✓ Good |
| **High Variance** | ✗ Bad |
| **Stability** | ✓ Good |
| **Bottom-Heavy Systems** | ✗ Bad |

Strategic Constraints

- Poor performance does not translate into meaningful draft benefit
- Traditional rebuild strategies provide limited value
- Middle-tier outcomes represent the worst-case scenario
- Organizational strategy must prioritize flexibility and downside protection

## 3. Evaluation Framework

To evaluate each proposal, I apply a Milwaukee-specific framework based on the team's competitive position and limited access to draft capital. The criteria focus on how each system impacts teams that are competitive but draft constrained.

| Criteria | What it Measures |
|---|---|
| Access to Draft Upside | Ability to improve draft position without requiring bottom-tier performance |
| Downside Protection | Degree to which decline still results in meaningful draft value |
| Value Distribution | Whether draft value is concentrated or spread across standings |
| Competitive Alignment | Whether the system rewards or penalizes competitive teams |
| Variance of Outcomes | Level of unpredictability and associated risk |

| Concept | Bucks Preference |
|---|---|
| **Draft Upside** | Accessible without bottoming out |
| **Downside Protection** | Minimized |
| **Value Distribution** | Flatter across standings |
| **Competitive Alignment** | Reward staying competitive |
| **Variance** | Lower preferred |

*Figure 3*

These criteria emphasize stability, flexibility, and protection against unrewarded decline, which are critical given Milwaukee's current roster construction and lack of draft control.

Using this framework, each proposal is evaluated based on how well it preserves value for competitive but draft-constrained teams like Milwaukee.

## 4. Proposal Analysis Sections

### a. Proposal 1: 18-Team Flattened Lottery

| System Overview | Milwaukee-Specific Impact |
|---|---|
| - 18 teams in lottery (7-15 both conferences)<br>- Bottom 10 all at 8%<br>- Remaining odds spread across 11-18<br>- Lottery determines all 18 picks | - Enters lottery more consistently<br>- Maintains access to meaningful draft outcomes<br>- Reduces penalty for marginal performance decline<br>- Increased upward movement opportunity |

**Evaluation Using Framework**

| Access to Draft Upside | Downside Protection | Value Distribution |
|---|---|---|
| - Big improvement vs current system<br>- Non-zero chance at meaningful jump<br>- No need to bottom out | - If Bucks decline slightly → still in lottery pool<br>- Avoid "middle-tier dead zone" | - Value spread more evenly<br>- Helps teams like Milwaukee more than current system |
| Verdict: ✓Higher | Verdict: ⚠️Limited | Verdict: ✓Balanced |
| **Competitive Alignment** | **Variance of Outcomes** | |
| - Does not punish winning teams as harshly<br>- Rewards staying competitive | - Flattened odds = more randomness<br>- Reduces structural disadvantage tied to standings | |
| Verdict: ✓Strong | Verdict: ✗Higher | |

**Key Insights from Visualized Outcomes**

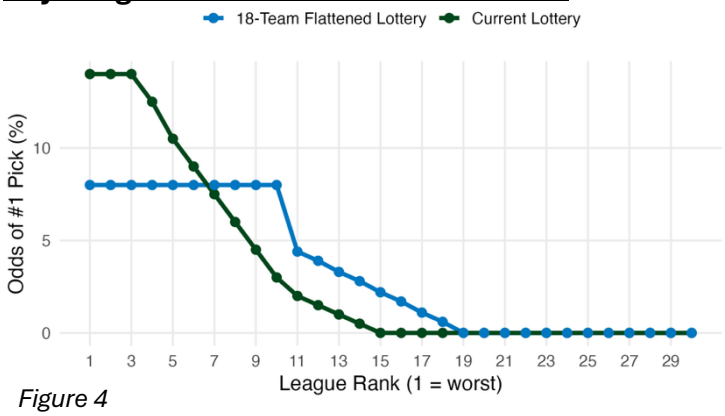



*Figure 4*

- Mid-tier upside increases
- Downside risk reduced in decline scenarios
- More balanced value redistributed
- Increase in outcome variability

**Interpretation for Milwaukee**

Flattened odds improve Milwaukee's expected outcomes without requiring a rebuild, primarily by increasing mid-tier value and reducing downside risk, increasing the overall variance compared to the current system.

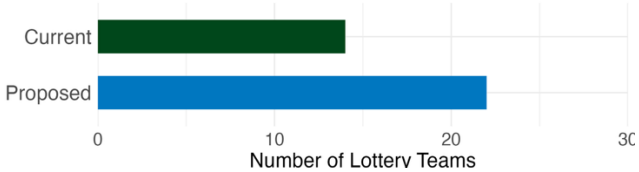
### b. Proposal 2: 22-Team, 2-Year Record Lottery

| System Overview | Milwaukee-Specific Impact |
|---|---|
| - 22 teams in lottery (non-playoff teams + 1st round exits)<br>- Odds based on a 2-year cumulative record<br>- Minimum win floor (25 wins per season)<br>- Lottery for only top 4 picks | - Could enter lottery more consistently, even as a playoff team<br>- 2-year record reduces impact of a single down season<br>- Limits benefits of short-term tanking → favors sustained competitiveness<br>- Expanded lottery pool significantly dilutes practical draft upside |

**Evaluation Using Framework**

| Access to Draft Upside | Downside Protection | Value Distribution |
|---|---|---|
| - Conditional access via 1st round exit<br>- 22-team pool heavily dilutes odds at jumps<br>- Limited ability to improve draft position | - 2-year record smooths poor years<br>- Win floor prevents extreme decline<br>- Stabilizes outcomes | - Value spread across larger group<br>- Reduces relative advantage for mid-tier teams |
| Verdict: ⚠️Limited | Verdict: ✓Strong | Verdict: ⚠️Diluted |
| **Competitive Alignment** | **Variance of Outcomes** | |
| - Rewards sustained competitiveness<br>- Rewards sustained performance over single-season outcomes<br>- Benefits broadly spread rather than targeted | - Larger pool increases randomness<br>- 2-year record stabilizes extremes<br>- Net effect: moderate, but limited impact<br>- Only for top 4 picks | |
| Verdict: ⚠️Neutral | Verdict: ✓Low | |

**Key Insights from Visualized Outcomes**




| Outcome | Current System | Proposed System |
|---|---|---|
| Miss Playoffs | ✓ Lottery | ✓ Lottery |
| Make Playoffs + Lose Round 1 | ✗ No Lottery | ✓ Lottery |
| Make Playoffs + Win Round 1 | ✗ No Lottery | ✗ No Lottery |

*Figure 5 (top) & Figure 6 (bottom)*

- Lottery expands from 14 → 22 teams
- Milwaukee gains conditional lottery access (via 1st round exit)
- Odds for top picks diluted across larger pool
- Limited improvement in expected draft outcomes

**Interpretation for Milwaukee**

While this system increases Milwaukee's access to the lottery, the expansion to a 22-team pool significantly dilutes the probability of meaningful outcomes. As a result, increased access does not translate into improved expected draft value.

### c. Proposal 3: "5 by 5" Lottery

| System Overview | Milwaukee-Specific Impact |
|---|---|
| - 18 teams in lottery (7-15 seeds in each conference)<br>- Bottom 5 teams receive equal odds at top picks<br>- 2-stage lottery system (top 5 picks, then remaining 13)<br>- Bottom 5 teams guaranteed no worse than 10th pick | - Enter the lottery pool more frequently<br>- Bottom 5 protection limits access to highest-value draft outcomes<br>- Mid-tier teams compete for remaining lottery positions with reduced odds<br>- Structured system reduces extreme downside movement in draft order |

**Evaluation Using Framework**

| Access to Draft Upside | Downside Protection | Value Distribution |
|---|---|---|
| - Lottery expands to 18<br>- Top 5 effectively limited to bottom 5 teams<br>- Little opportunity for meaningful jumps into top tier | - Inclusion provides minimum lottery access<br>- Structure limits extreme movement<br>- Limited protection for mid-tier teams | - Top-end value concentrated in bottom 5<br>- Remaining teams compete for lower-value picks<br>- Sharp drop-off in value beyond top tier |
| Verdict: ⚠️Moderate | Verdict: ⚠️Limited | Verdict: ❌Bottom-heavy |
| **Competitive Alignment** | **Variance of Outcomes** | |
| - Broader lottery access for non-bottom teams<br>- Core incentives still favor bottom-tier positioning<br>- Limited benefits elsewhere | - 2-stage system reduces randomness<br>- Limits extreme upward movement<br>- More predictable outcomes | |
| Verdict: ❌Weak | Verdict: ⚠️Moderate | |

**Key Insights from Visualized Outcomes**

| Structure of Outcomes | Implications for MIL |
|---|---|
| - Tier break after 1-5<br>- Top picks focused<br>- Compressed value for remaining teams | - Not in protected tier<br>- Small top-end value<br>- Greater stability, but less opportunity |

| Rank | Access | Upside |
|---|---|---|
| 1-5 | 🟢 Full | 🔥 High |
| 6-10 | 🟡 Partial | ⚡ Moderate |
| 11-18 | 🟠 Limited | ⬇️ Low |
| 19-30 | 🔴 None | ❌ None |

*Figure 7*

**Interpretation for Milwaukee**

The two-tier structure concentrates top-end draft value within the bottom 5 teams, effectively limiting access to high-impact outcomes for teams like Milwaukee. While the system increases predictability, it does so at the cost of meaningful upside.

## 5. Comparative Analysis

| Criteria | Proposal 1 | Proposal 2 | Proposal 3 |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Draft Upside** | ✅ Higher | ❌ Limited | ⚠️ Moderate |
| **Downside Protection** | ⚠️ Limited | ✅ Strong | ⚠️ Limited |
| **Value Distribution** | ✅ Balanced | ⚠️ Diluted | ❌ Bottom-heavy |
| **Competitive Alignment** | ✅ Strong | ⚠️ Neutral | ❌ Weak |
| **Variance** | ❌ Higher | ✅ Low | ⚠️ Moderate |

*Figure 8*

| Proposal 1 | Proposal 2 | Proposal 3 |
|---|---|---|
| Increases upward mobility without requiring bottom-tier positioning | Expands access without meaningful improvement in outcomes | Concentrates top-end outcomes among bottom teams |
| Improves expected outcomes in mid-tier range | Dilutes odds across large lottery pool | Limits access to premium draft positions |
| Reduces exposure to unrewarded decline | Provides downside protection but limited upside | Provides structure but restricts opportunity |

Key Tradeoffs

| | |
|---|---|
| Access vs Value | Proposal 2 expands access but dilutes meaningful outcomes, while Proposal 1 maintains both access and value. |
| Structure vs Opportunity | Proposal 3 improves predictability but restricts access to top-tier outcomes, limiting its usefulness for Milwaukee. |
| Downside Protection vs Upside | Proposal 2 provides the strongest downside protection but lacks sufficient upside to meaningfully improve outcomes. |
| Relevance to Milwaukee's Range | Proposal 1 most directly improves outcomes in the range where Milwaukee is most likely to operate. |

While each proposal introduces different structural changes, only Proposal 1 meaningfully improves expected outcomes for Milwaukee. Proposal 2 increases access but fails to deliver sufficient value, while Proposal 3 maintains structure at the cost of opportunity. As a result, Proposal 1 provides the strongest overall alignment with Milwaukee's strategic priorities.

## 6. Strategic Implications for Milwaukee

The evaluation of these proposals highlights several broader strategic principles relevant to Milwaukee's roster construction and long-term planning.

Core Strategic Principles

- Draft systems should be evaluated based on outcomes in Milwaukee's likely operating range, not theoretical upside
- Avoid structures where value is concentrated among bottom-tier teams
- Increased lottery access is only valuable if it translates into meaningful outcomes
- Downside protection is critical given limited control over future picks
- Systems that reduce exposure to unrewarded decline provide the greatest strategic value

Organizational Implications

- Milwaukee's team-building strategy will continue to rely on trades, development, and marginal roster improvements
- Draft reform does not eliminate the need to maintain a competitive baseline
- Avoiding decline is more valuable than maximizing unlikely upside scenarios
- Preferred systems are those that preserve flexibility without requiring bottom-tier positioning

For Milwaukee, the optimal draft system is not one that maximizes theoretical upside, but one that minimizes the risk of unrewarded decline while preserving access to incremental improvement.

## 7. Final Ranking & Recommendation

Based on the Milwaukee-specific evaluation framework, the three proposals can be ranked as follows:

1. Proposal 1 – 18-Team Flattened Lottery
   Provides the best balance of access, value, and protection against unrewarded decline by improving outcomes without requiring bottom-tier positioning.

2. Proposal 2 – 22-Team, 2-Year Record Lottery
   Expands access but fails to deliver meaningful improvement due to heavily diluted odds.

3. Proposal 3 – "5 by 5" Lottery
   Maintains structure but concentrates top-end value among bottom teams, limiting practical benefit.

Milwaukee should strongly prefer Proposal 1, as it provides the most balanced and strategically aligned structure by increasing access to meaningful outcomes while minimizing the risk of unrewarded decline.